Parshas Korach

Holy Fire in the Right Vessel

Korach · The Kohen Gadol · The Fire Pans · Shmuel and the King

I. Where It All Started

As we go into Parshas Korach, this parsha carries a very personal marker for me. For those who have been following for a longer period of time, Korach is where this whole format of published Divrei Torah began. I already mentioned this in connection to Sefer Bamidbar generally, but specifically, Parshas Korach was the first week I shared something publicly in this format. A friend posted in my shul's WhatsApp group that they were looking for someone to do a dvar Torah for the week. I put something together, sent it in, and a number of people reached out afterward and said they really liked it and wanted more. And here we are, a whole year later. That is kind of wild.

A small moment, a small yes, can become a real marker in life. Something you look back to and say, this is where something began. So this year, coming back to Korach, I want to try something a little different. We will look not only at the parsha itself but also bring in the Haftorah and see how it deepens everything the parsha is asking of us.

II. The Rebellion and the Man Behind It

Korach leads a rebellion. His argument, on the surface, sounds almost compelling. The whole nation is holy. Hashem dwells among all of them. Why should Moshe and Aharon raise themselves above everyone else? It almost sounds like a case for equality, for shared holiness, for everyone having a place. And that is exactly what makes it dangerous. Korach was using the language of kedusha to pursue something that had nothing to do with kedusha.

What did he actually want? He wanted to be Kohen Gadol. He wanted the kavod, the position, the centrality. And he pulled in Shevet Reuven to join him, which, when you think about it carefully, does not even make sense. Shevet Reuven had no shaychus to the kehunah whatsoever. The entire dispute was about who should be Kohen Gadol. That was the test. That was the stated challenge. Why would Shevet Reuven be involved in a dispute about the Kohen Gadol when they had no claim to it in the first place? But that is what

happens when a persuasive person with a narcissistic drive builds a movement. The logic does not have to hold perfectly. It just has to feel compelling enough for people to follow.

Korach himself was not a small person. He was not without greatness. Chazal tell us he had ruach hakodesh. He saw that great descendants would come from him, including Shmuel HaNavi. He saw his future, saw the holiness connected to his name, and from that drew the conclusion that he must be right, that his present claim must be justified because his future was holy. But that is not how truth works. The fact that something good will eventually emerge from you does not mean every road you take to get there is correct.

III. The Kohen Gadol and the Rope

To understand what makes Korach's behavior so striking, we need to look at the real thing he was claiming to want: the role of Kohen Gadol. And specifically, what that role actually looked like in practice.

During the time of the second Beis HaMikdash, and this reality existed during the first as well, there was a well-known practice on Yom Kippur. When the Kohen Gadol entered the Kodesh HaKadoshim, a rope would be tied around him. The reason was simple and sobering: if he was not worthy, if something went wrong in that most sacred of moments, no one else could enter to retrieve him. He was going in alone, into the holiest place on earth, on the holiest day of the year, and he knew he might not come back out.

The Kohen Gadol was aware of his own mortality going in. There was a genuine fear involved. And yet there was also what we might call a chutzpah d'kedusha, a holy kind of audacity. He felt his own koach. He believed in what he was doing. He was willing to walk into that room knowing that if he was not on the level required, the consequences would fall on him. He was putting himself at risk for the sake of avodas Hashem and for the sake of Klal Yisrael. That is what the Kohen Gadol accepted as part of the role.

Now look at Korach. He also wanted to be Kohen Gadol. He also wanted that position of serving at the highest level. But when the test came, the actual high-stakes moment where everything would be decided, Korach was counting on his own survival. He had seen through ruach hakodesh that his descendants would live. He interpreted that as a guarantee that he personally would come through. He was willing to risk his sons, his followers, the 250 people around him, and Shevet Reuven who had no stake in the outcome at all. Everyone else was expendable. He was not.

That is the contrast in full. The Kohen Gadol walks into the Kodesh HaKadoshim knowing he might die, willing to take that risk upon himself for Hashem and for the nation. Korach walks into his test willing to let everyone around him die while expecting to emerge on top. I am not a psychiatrist and I am not here to formally diagnose anyone. But the pattern is recognizable. Someone who places his own survival, his own kavod, his own vision so far above everything else that even his own family becomes secondary to the image he is building, that is not leadership. That is self-centeredness wrapped in the clothing of avodas Hashem. And that is what earned Korach the particular place in the tradition he has occupied ever since.

IV. Gathering Followers Is Not the Same as Leading

Using this drive, Korach managed to build a massive following. He had 250 people bringing ketores alongside him. He had Shevet Reuven, who again had nothing to gain from the outcome. He was able to gather people, to make them feel they were fighting for something holy and fair, to turn his personal ambition into a communal movement. And that is worth examining, because it happens in every generation.

There are people who are leaders, and there are people who are very good at gathering followers. There is a real difference. True leadership means taking responsibility for the people in your care, putting their welfare above your own position. What Korach had was the ability to make people feel they were part of something important, while the actual goal was his own elevation. Gathering followers is not leading. It can look the same from the outside, especially when the one doing it is articulate and convincing and framing everything in holy language. But the direction is entirely different. And the destruction that follows from false leadership is what the parsha documents in brutal detail.

V. The Fire Pans and What Gets Elevated

The rebellion comes to its end. The earth opens, a briah chadasha, a new creation as Rashi and the mefarshim describe, and swallows Korach and his core group. The 250 who brought the ketores are consumed by fire. A plague follows. And then, in the aftermath, something unexpected and theologically striking happens.

Hashem commands that the fire pans of the 250 men be collected. These were the pans used in a forbidden avodah, in a direct rebellion against the structure Hashem had given. One would expect them to be destroyed. We have halachic concepts for when a kli has been used in a way that leaves no future sanctity. But Hashem says the opposite. These

pans are kadosh. They are taken and hammered into a covering for the outer Mizbeach, where they would be visible to all of Klal Yisrael as a reminder.

On one level, yes, the reminder is a warning: do not challenge the kehunah. But the deeper point is what it says about the people who held those pans. They were not running away from Hashem. They wanted avodah. They wanted to bring ketores. They wanted to be part of something elevated. They missed the mark badly, in a way that cost them their lives, but there was a real koach there, a genuine desire for closeness with Hashem, that did not simply disappear along with them. The kli that carried that desire was brought into the Mishkan rather than discarded. Because even avodah done in the wrong way, aimed at Hashem rather than away from Him, carries a residue of kedusha that Hashem does not simply erase.

And then there is something else that happens in the immediate aftermath of all this death and destruction. A new plague breaks out among Klal Yisrael, and Aharon runs out with ketores to stop it. The same ketores that was used in the rebellion, that was the instrument of death for the 250, becomes in Aharon's hands the instrument of salvation. The same substance, brought by the right person in the right way for the right purpose, stops a plague. That reversal is not accidental. It is the Torah showing us that the koach of ketores itself was always real. The problem was never the fire. The problem was always who was holding it and why.

VI. Eliyahu HaNavi: The Outside Act That Points Inward

There is a story from Tanach that casts a long shadow over everything in this parsha, even though it is not the Haftorah. When we look at Eliyahu HaNavi on Har HaCarmel, we see something that on the surface resembles what the 250 men did: an avodah brought outside the proper framework, a korban offered in a place and manner that was not technically permitted under normal circumstances.

Eliyahu gathers the people for a public test between the prophets of Baal and the truth of Hashem. He builds a Mizbeach and brings a korban outside the Beis HaMikdash. Under ordinary halacha this would be forbidden. But Eliyahu acts as a navi, with reshus, in a hora'as sha'ah, a one-time emergency prophetic act, for one explicit purpose: to bring Klal Yisrael back to Hashem. The drought ends. The avodah zarah is exposed. The people return.

What separates Eliyahu from Korach and the 250 is not the external structure of the action. Both involved bringing fire in a context outside the standard framework. The difference is entirely in the inner direction. Korach's movement was toward himself, toward his own kavod and position. The 250's desire was real but unaligned. Eliyahu's movement was purely toward Hashem, to restore the order Hashem had given, not to challenge or replace it. The same kind of outside act can be holy or destructive depending entirely on whether the self is at the center or Hashem is. That distinction is one of the deepest things Sefer Bamidbar keeps asking us to examine in ourselves.

VII. The Haftorah: Wanting a King

The Haftorah for Parshas Korach comes from Sefer Shmuel, and it deals with Klal Yisrael asking for a king. At first the connection to Korach is not obvious. What is wrong with wanting a king? The Torah itself discusses the mitzvah of appointing a Jewish king. A king can provide order, direction, unity, and national leadership. The request sounds legitimate.

But Shmuel rebukes them. And the reason touches the same nerve as Korach. They wanted a physical king in a way that reflected a weakening of their awareness that Hashem is their true Melech. They wanted a human being they could see and point to and follow, in a way that pushed aside the direct reality of Hashem's kingship over them. It is the same pattern we have seen throughout. Korach accused Moshe of making himself like a king while Korach himself wanted that authority. The people of Shmuel's time look at the surrounding nations and say they want what those nations have, while what they are doing is trading the reality of Hashem as King for something more visible and immediate. In both cases the desire sounds reasonable on the outside. In both cases the internal misalignment is the real issue.

Shmuel teaches them something worth sitting with. A request can be externally legitimate and still internally misaligned. The problem is not always the object of the desire. Sometimes the problem is the inner place from which the desire comes. Korach says he wants holiness. The 250 say they want avodah. Klal Yisrael says they want a king. Each sounds reasonable. The real question is always the same: is this bringing me closer to Hashem, or am I using holy language to place something else at the center?

VIII. Ki Lo Yitosh

And then the Haftorah does something remarkable. After the rebuke, after naming clearly where Klal Yisrael went wrong, Shmuel does not leave them in despair. He says:

כִּי לֹא יִטֹּשׁ ה׳ אֶת עַמּוֹ בַּעֲבוּר שְׁמוֹ הַגָּדוֹל

"For Hashem will not abandon His people, for the sake of His great Name."

— Shmuel I 12:22

Even when we miss the mark, we are still His. That is the same lesson as the fire pans. The pans were used in a failed and forbidden avodah and brought back into kedusha. Klal Yisrael asked for a king from the wrong place and remained Hashem's people. Korach's sons did teshuvah and we have Tehillim from them. The same koach that was used for destruction became a source of kedusha for generations. Misdirected kochos do not always need to be destroyed. They need to be redirected. The fire does not always need to be extinguished. It needs the right vessel.

This does not excuse the mistakes. It does not make rebellion holy or erase the danger of ego and machlokes. But it teaches us that when we miss the mark, when our kochos go in the wrong direction, Hashem does not discard us along with the mistake. The kli can still be elevated. And that is as true for us as it was for anyone in this parsha.

IX. Coming Back to Where This Began

Korach could have been so much more. He had greatness in him, real koach, real influence, a future connected to holiness. But he allowed his self-centeredness to overwhelm him. He used his power to challenge the place Hashem had given to someone else rather than to serve Hashem fully from the place Hashem had given to him. And the gap between what he could have been and what he chose is the real tragedy of the parsha.

His followers were also missing the mark, but they were close. They were committed to something beautiful, just not in the way Torah allowed. And that closeness is what the fire pans represent. The desire was real. The direction was off. Hashem preserved the koach even while correcting the direction.

Coming back to this parsha a year after it all began, the questions it leaves us with feel personal. Where am I trying to be too big for my avodah? Where am I using holy language but placing myself at the center? Where do I have a kli of kedusha that needs to be redirected rather than destroyed? And how am I crowning Hashem as Melech over my own life rather than crowning my own needs and vision? Because the goal of avodah is

not to become the center. The goal is to connect to Hashem, to serve Him, to learn Torah, to become an eved Hashem from whatever place He has actually given us. Not everyone is the Kohen Gadol. Not everyone brings the ketores. But every Jew can help supply it. Every Jew can take his fire, his keilim, his passion and longing, and bring them back into the framework of Torah. The fire pans were lifted into the Mishkan. So can we be.

חזק ואחזק

Good Shabbos

Reflection Questions

- *Where might I be trying to be too big for my avodah? Where am I using the language of kedusha to pursue something that is really about my own kavod?*
- *The Kohen Gadol risked himself for Hashem and the nation. Korach risked everyone around him while expecting to survive. Where in my life do I take on risk for others, and where am I putting others at risk for my own goals?*
- *Where do I have a kli of kedusha, a genuine desire for closeness with Hashem, that is being aimed in the wrong direction? What would redirecting it look like?*
- *Am I gathering followers or actually leading people? What is the difference in how I show up for those around me?*
- *The same ketores that brought death in Korach's rebellion brought salvation in Aharon's hands. Where in my own life has something that went wrong become, in the right hands and at the right time, a source of healing?*
- *Looking back at this past year: what has Hashem given me? What grew from a small yes, a small moment of showing up? And how am I crowning Him as Melech over what comes next?*